

WHODUNNIT Vijay Raaz and Ashutosh Rana in a scene from the show

Murder in Mahim emerged from Jerry Pinto's rage in 2017. While the Delhi High Court decriminalised homosexual acts between consenting adults in 2009, the Supreme Court overturned the ruling in 2013, causing widespread disappointment and rage among India's LGBTQ community and their allies.

"I was moved by anger, the anger that an old-fashioned and ridiculous law could criminalise ten per cent of India who happen to love people of the same sex," recalls Pinto.

The murder mystery novel, which followed journalist Peter Fernandes and cop Shiva Jende investigating serial murders of gay men who have sexual encounters in suburban railway station toilets, is now a Hindi web series streaming on JioCinema. Ashutosh Rana plays Peter, Vijay Raaz Shiva.

The suspense is kicked off with the corpse of a brutally murdered man found in a public toilet alongside Matunga Road railway station bridge in Mumbai. While the hardboiled Shiva investigates in a routine fashion, retired journalist Peter has some soul-searching to do as he grapples with his adult son's homosexuality in the course of following the blood and mayhem.

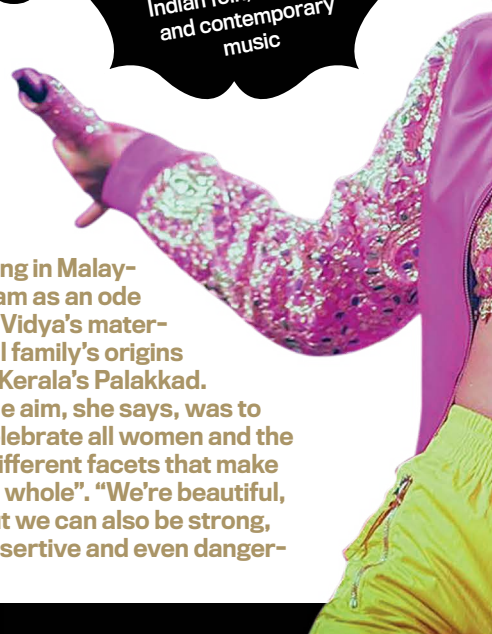
"I was attracted to how Peter is a well-read man with modern thoughts, and is yet a conservative who slowly changes as the milieu of the crime enters his own home," says Rana. "It was also interesting how the police investigate a crime but a journalist tries to understand the society from which the crime emerges."

MUSIC

In Her Mother's Voice

Vidya Vox's exuberant new EP, *Sundari*, is primarily in Tamil as a tribute to her mother

SUNDARI bears the signature sound crafted by Vidya and is a canny mix of pop, electronic and hip-hop with Indian folk, classical and contemporary music



Longtime listeners of singer/songwriter Vidya Vox, aka Vidya Iyer, will notice a key difference between her new EP *Sundari* and her previous mini albums, *Kuthu Fire* (2017) and *Mad Dreams* (2019). The new effort is primarily in Tamil whereas the earlier sets were mostly in English. She attributes the shift to the inspiration behind *Sundari*. "I wanted to specifically make it in Tamil because the EP was inspired by my mom and the journey I've seen her go through," says Vidya. "Tamil is my mother tongue and I felt like [her story] was best articulated in that language."

Vidya, who grew up with an abusive father, was 16 when her mother decided to flee their violent home with her two daughters. Despite this, *Sundari* feels exuberant. The title track is a funky flex about both desirability and desire, while '*Ini Ninte Lokam* (Go Off)' is a percussive woman power anthem sung in Malayalam as an ode to Vidya's maternal family's origins in Kerala's Palakkad. The aim, she says, was to celebrate all women and the "different facets that make us whole". "We're beautiful, but we can also be strong, assertive and even danger-